

CORE FORMULA

Signal + tentative label + choice + respectful follow-through. -> When you mentioned the new role, you had a lot more detail. Is that the thread to stay with? -> You lit up a bit when travel came up. Want to talk about that, or keep this practical? -> Your answer got more specific around the customer side. Should we spend more time there? -> More energy showed up around [topic]. Stay there, or move on?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Notice the one topic that had more energy, name it softly, and hand over the choice: "You seemed more interested when we got to [topic] — want to stay there, or keep moving?"

BEST FOR

- Open social conversations with several possible topics
- First meetings where the shared interest is still being found
- Interviews, discovery calls, coaching, mentoring, and facilitation
- Team conversations where one thread suddenly becomes more useful
- Digital chats where reply length, specificity, and timing reveal interest
- Moments where someone briefly lights up before the conversation moves on too fast

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short one-liners

- "More energy on [topic]?"
- "Is [topic] the more interesting thread here?"
- "Stay with [topic], or keep moving?"
- "That part seems to have more juice. Is it?"
- "You lit up a bit there. Want to stay with it?"
- "More detail showed up around [topic]. Stay there, or move on?"
- "Want me to follow this thread?"

Social / catch-up · Warm social checks

- "You seemed more animated when you mentioned [topic]. Want to stay there for a bit?"
- "You sounded a little brighter on the [topic] part. Want to talk about that, or is work the main thing?"
- "I noticed you smiled when [topic] came up. Is that a better thread?"
- "We can keep going here, or go back to [topic] if that is more interesting."
- "You had more detail on the climbing trip than on work. Want to stay with that?"
- "That sounds like the part you actually enjoy. Shall we start there?"

Professional / meetings · Workplace focus selection

- "The [topic] part seems to have more substance. Should we focus there?"
- "You gave more detail on [topic]. Is that where the real issue is?"
- "I am hearing more energy around [topic] than [topic B]. Which should we prioritise?"
- "Would it be useful to pause on [topic], or keep the agenda moving?"
- "The [topic] thread seems to have more signal than the timeline. Should we spend five minutes there?"
- "Implementation risk seems to be the more important thread. Should we cover that before budget?"

Choice framing · Explicit two-option checks

- "We can stay with [topic], or I can answer the original question directly. Which is more useful?"

- "Do you want to go into the people side or the process side? I noticed more energy around the people side."
- "Which thread is most useful to stay with right now?"
- "Should we spend two minutes on [topic], or keep moving?"
- "Is [topic] the part that needs attention, or is it just context?"
- "We can park [topic] and follow [topic B] for five minutes. Your call."

Digital / text · Text-based calibration

- "Your last reply had a lot more detail around [topic]. Want to unpack that?"
- "Seems like [topic] may be the more useful thread. I can follow that if you want."
- "This part seems to have more detail for you. Want me to follow it?"
- "You came back to [topic] twice. Worth a proper thread?"
- "Happy to stay on [topic] or answer the original question — whichever helps."

High-pressure & boundary-preserving · Guarded or consent-sensitive contexts

- "I do not want to overread this. Is [topic] the key issue, or should I stay with the original point?"
- "Only if useful: should we spend two minutes on [topic]?"
- "I may be misreading the signal. What would be most useful to focus on?"
- "No need to go into it if it is private. I noticed [topic] might matter, so I wanted to check."
- "We can leave that alone. I only named it because it seemed relevant."
- "If that is not a topic for now, we can move on."
- "Only if useful — we can skip this entirely."

Softening & release · Clean releases after a misread

- "Got it — let's leave that."
- "That was my read, not yours. What should we focus on?"
- "I named it too strongly. Let me back up."
- "We can leave that aside. What would be useful instead?"
- "No pressure either way — happy to move on."
- "Fair enough. Which thread actually helps here?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: You obviously want to talk about your job.

Better: You had a lot to say when your job came up. Is that worth talking about?

Best: When you mentioned the job change, you gave more detail than anywhere else. I may be misreading it, but is that a useful thread to stay with, or would you rather leave it?

2. Weak: So your real issue is the manager.

Better: The manager piece sounds important. Should we focus there?

Best: Your answer got more specific when the manager came up. Is that the part that needs attention, or is it just context?

DECISION TREE

If A topic clearly lifted in energy, detail, or specificity

Name the signal softly and offer a choice

"I noticed more detail around [topic]. Worth staying with, or should we move on?"

If The topic is private, unsafe, or outside the conversation's purpose

Do not pursue it; acknowledge lightly or move on

"That might be one for another time — no need to get into it now."

If You cannot name the signal without sounding intrusive

Offer a broader, neutral choice instead

"Which thread is most useful to stay with?"

If They expand after the check

Follow the thread and develop it with live-thread follow-ups or threading

"Good — what changed in your view?"

If They correct you

Thank them and follow the correction, not your read
"Thanks — so the real thread is [topic B]. Let's go there."

If They contract, or the topic matters but the timing is wrong

Release it, or bookmark it with permission
"Let's park that — shall we come back to it later?"

SCENARIOS

Social catch-up

Compare their politeness about work with their specificity about a hobby, then hand over the choice. — "You had more detail on the climbing trip than on work. Want to stay with that?"

Team meeting

Name the thread with the most group signal and time-box it. — "The customer-feedback thread seems to have more signal than the timeline. Should we spend five minutes there?"

Client conversation

Follow the thread they expand on, but never use the signal to pressure a buying decision. — "Implementation risk seems to be the more important thread. Should we cover that before budget?"

Mentoring or coaching

Test the animated thread gently; back off if it starts to feel too personal. — "You sounded more alive on the mentoring piece. Is that where you want to look?"

Digital chat

When a short thread suddenly gets a long, detailed reply, offer to follow it — and do not chase silence. — "This part seems to have more detail for you. Want me to follow this thread?"

High-power-difference setting

Add extra consent so the check can be declined at no cost. — "Only if useful — we can skip this. Is [topic] worth a couple of minutes?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They have stated a boundary or asked to stop
- There is an urgent agenda, safety issue, or legal, medical, or HR process
- You are tempted to use the signal to push a sale, flirtation, or confession
- They are tired, distressed, or under pressure and need simplicity, not exploration
- The topic is private or high-stakes and you do not have consent to explore it
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Signal spotting

After one conversation, list three topics that came up. For each, write only the observable signals — detail, pace, tone, callback, question, example — and no guesses about motive.

Day 2 — Read the baseline

Pick one person you talk to often. Note their normal pace and detail level, so you can tell a genuine lift from their usual style.

Day 3 — Soft-check reps

Write five versions of "I noticed more [signal] around [topic]. Is that the useful thread?", each one softer and less certain than the last.

Day 4 — Release practice

Rehearse three clean releases for "No, not really": "Got it — let's leave that", "Thanks, I misread it", and "What would be more useful?"

Day 5 — Digital calibration

Review three text or email threads. Mark where reply length, specificity, or speed changed, and draft one preference check for each — sending it only if it would be welcome.

Day 6 — One live rep

In a low-stakes conversation, use exactly one preference check and then stop. Note whether the person expanded, corrected, or contracted.

Day 7 — Compare and choose

In a conversation with two live threads, name both and hand over the choice — "I'm seeing [A] and [B]; which is more useful?" — then follow their answer, not your preference.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- What exact signal did I notice — and was it observable, not assumed?
- Did I compare it against this person's normal baseline?
- Did I name it tentatively and offer a genuine choice?
- Did I follow their answer instead of my preferred path?
- Did I release the topic cleanly when they did not want it?
- Did I use it sparingly enough that the conversation still felt natural?